

Personal Essay

Name: Rupa Shrestha

Student ID: 4266261

Professor's Name: Hamideh Zakeri

Introduction

The Social and Ethical Issues class taught by our professor, Hamideh Zakeri, has been a wonderful learning experience that I will always remember. This course offered a mix of theory and real-life examples, encouraging us to think deeply about the ethical side of data. It gave me a chance to explore how data impacts our world and the challenges that come with it. In this essay, I will share my thoughts on what I learned, what I enjoyed, and what could have made the class even better.

Body

One of the best parts of this class was learning about data-related issues and challenges in data analysis. It helped me see the bigger picture of how data affects people's lives. I really enjoyed reading the two books assigned: *Weapons of Math Destruction* by Cathy O'Neil and *Everybody Lies* by Seth Stephens-Davidowitz. O'Neil's book stood out to me because it showed how data models can sometimes make unfair decisions and hurt people, especially in areas like education and hiring. It made me realize how powerful data is and why it is so important to use it responsibly. Stephens-Davidowitz's book was also fascinating. It showed how people's online behavior can reveal surprising truths about society. Both books opened my eyes to the good and bad sides of data analysis.

In addition to the books, the class discussions were another highlight. I loved hearing different perspectives from my classmates, who all brought unique ideas and experiences to the table. These discussions helped me understand the books and topics even better. It was inspiring to see how everyone interpreted the lessons in their own way. However, I think the class could have been even better if we had weekly student presentations on real-world data issues. This would have given us more chances to practice public speaking and share our ideas with others. As someone who is introverted, I know I need to improve my speaking skills, and having weekly presentations would have been a great way to build confidence step by step. It also would have helped us stay updated on real-world data case studies. Although the final presentation at the end of the class is a good way to wrap up our learning, more regular presentations would have been helpful for people like me. Weekly practice would have made us more comfortable with presenting and allowed us to explore a wider range of data-related topics. Even so, I still appreciated the final presentation as it gave us a chance to share what we had learned and apply the course concepts to real-life situations.

Another part of the class that I found valuable was working on my research paper about the use of AI in candidate application screening. This project taught me so much about how companies use AI to hire people, and the ethical challenges involved. I learned about the biases that can exist in AI systems and how they can affect fairness in hiring. Writing this paper made me think about how important it is for companies to use AI tools responsibly and consider their impact on people. This experience helped me understand the connection between technology, ethics, and social responsibility.

Conclusion

In conclusion, the Social and Ethical Issues class was a meaningful and rewarding experience. It gave me a better understanding of how data shapes our world and the importance of using it ethically. I really enjoyed the class materials, the engaging discussions, and the chance to learn from my professor and classmates. While I wish there were more opportunities for regular presentations, I am grateful for everything I learned in this class. Overall, this class has been an invaluable part of my academic journey, helping me grow both academically and personally, and I am excited to use these lessons in my future work in data analysis.